feet, which then opens up towards the north like an amphitheatre. The flat area, surrounded on three sides by rugged rocky peaks, harbours two small lakes bordered by patches of rhododendron bushes.

The Nuranang Chu emanates from one of the lakes and is joined by another stream coming in from the direction of Kya-la to the east. Three kilometres to the northwest of Se-la Top, the valley begins to slant down towards Nuranang, which is another seven kilometres away. The crystal clear waters of the Nuranang Chu run down a sharply constricted valley with lightly wooded slopes on either side. The road then begins to drop sharply towards Jang, which is a Monpa village on the northern slopes overlooking the Tawang Chu (also known as the Mago Chu) down below.

The premature withdrawal from Jang after last light the previous day had created a void between the Indian and Chinese positions. 4 Garhwal Rifles, after blowing up the bridge, had climbed up to Nuranang but left most of their heavy equipment behind, including four mortars. The artillery, too, in their headlong rush out of Jang, had left behind critical equipment without which the accuracy of the remaining six mountain guns was seriously hampered. Besides 1 Sikh and the three companies of 4 Garhwal Rifles, there were also elements of 13 Dogra between Nuranang and Se-la Top on the morning of 25 October. Meanwhile, from the southern side, 4 Sikh LI commanded by Lieutenant Colonel R. B. Nanda had also started to arrive at Se-la.

Through the previous day and most of the night, 1 Sikh had been busy with the preparation of defences at Se-la. The arrival of Harbaksh Singh and the new GOC, Anant Pathania, at Se-la Top during the morning hours sent a wave of excitement through the troops, who were still smarting from being pulled out of Bum-la just when they felt things were getting interesting. By late afternoon, 4 Garhwal had deployed below Nuranang with the 3.7-inch guns positioned next to the battalion’s defences. A company of 4 Sikh LI under the command of Captain Rosario, a Goan officer who not only spoke fluent Punjabi but also sported a turban, deployed in the Twin Lakes area.

Harbaksh and Anant Pathania were briefed by Palit, after which the corps commander did an independent reconnaissance of his own with Brigadier Nandi Lal, the commander of 62 Brigade. Harbaksh would have been aware that Bogey Sen, the Eastern Army Commander, as well as the staff of IV Corps, favoured falling back on the Bomdila axis, and that stocking Se-la to take on the Chinese would be a huge exercise in logistics.